

GP Media Revision Package

Introduction

Quotes

Censorship

“If you do not read the newspaper, you are uninformed. If you read the newspaper, you are mis-informed.” – American writer, Mark Twain

“Whenever they burn books they will also, in the end, burn human beings.” – German poet, Heinrich Heine

- Just as ... **emphatically opined**, censorship must be sedulously thought through as it could lead to **dire consequences** among the people.

Media and society

“There is so much comedy on television. Does that cause comedy in the streets?” – American television personality, Dick Cavett

- Just as the quote **meticulously points out**, what is disseminated in the media does not always reflect reality.

Impact of media

“What kills a skunk is the publicity it gives itself.” – 16th President of the United States, Abraham Lincoln

“He who controls the media controls the minds of the public.” – The father of modern linguistics, Noam Chomsky

- The quote **judiciously** points out the value and also the potentially dire consequences of media.

“Social media is like crack – immediately gratifying and hugely addictive” – New York Times best-selling author, Gary Vaynerchuk

- The quote **sheds light** on the nature of social media by comparing it with a cocaine, a strong and addictive drug with many negative impacts on the human body. Indeed, ...

Advertisements

“Doing business without advertising is like winking at a girl in the dark” – Marketing expert, Stuart H.

- Just as the quote **astutely** points out, advertisements have the power to determine the eventual outcome of a business. If done properly, a good advertisement could even revive a business on the verge of collapse. As such, businesses always want to make their advertisements as appealing and attractive as possible in order to utilize on the influence of ads and increase the sales of their products/services.

News

“Truth and news are not the same thing.” – American publisher, Katharine Graham

- Just as the quote **precisely** points out, news today no longer holds credit in publishing the truth.

1. Censorship

Possible questions:

1. Do you agree that freedom of speech should never be denied even though it can be abused?
2. Discuss the view that dissenting voices should be censored in your society.
3. Can restrictions on the mass media be justified when they are so difficult to enforce?

Stand: **Should be denied/censored/restricted**

Intro

- With the **proliferation of new media, bolstered by an explosion of information**, it seems as though Man now has a **versatile megaphone** to freely air his views to other similar individuals.
- However, freedom of expression is a **double-edged sword**, while it **emboldens the disenfranchised and oppressed** to voice out their opinions, an excess of it forces one to contend with the dire consequences which may jeopardise the very survival of a country due to terrorism, civil unrest, ethnic or religious strife.
- While there has indeed been a shift towards the increasingly misguided use of such liberation, proper regulations through responsible governance can effectively negate such consequences. Therefore, I am in agreement with the question that censorship should be imposed.

TS1 (Should):

An excessive privilege granted to dissenters to speak their mind may fuel their intentions to convey hate speech and incitements, **threatening peace and social stability** in societies.

Critical analysis

- Although freedom of speech is widely regarded as an **inalienable human right**, and justifiably so, when this freedom is abused, it becomes viewed by some as **a cloak of invisibility**.
- Extremist who are compelled by their own intentions uses this freedom as a tool for them to carry out their means to push past previous boundaries.
- Radical, extreme ideas can spread like wildfire without the curb of censorship potentially **spark highly disruptive and deleterious conflicts** in society along the lines of race and religion.

Examples

- A sterling example is **Al Qaeda's** utilisation of new media to spread their dangerous and misguided ideologies. Al Qaeda has utilized social media through the publication of Inspire, an online magazine that propagates racial Islam ideals and relevant information. This taught the **Tsarnaev brothers** how to build a pressure cooker bomb from scratch, which eventually led up to the **2013 Boston Marathon Bombings**.
- The Charlie Hebdo magazine published offensive and racist cartoons of Prophet Mohammad which aggravated Islamic extremists. This eventually culminated in the unfortunate **Charlie Hebdo shootings** in 2015.

Counter (Should not):

However, **Deontologists** may argue that placing any form of restrictions on the freedom of speech is **inherently wrong regardless of any tangential positive consequences it brings** as the freedom of speech is an inherent right of Man. Denying it can be viewed by many as a violation against universal human rights. According to Article 19 of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, everyone has the right to freedom of opinion and expression.

Rebuttal (Should):

That said, even bringing this argument to its strongest, it is undeniable that **maintaining a stable society should be prioritised** since the **sanctity of human life should be of the utmost priority**. If anything, **a tumultuous and anarchic society is the biggest violation of human rights itself** since it has the **potential to threaten an individual's right to life**.

TS2 (Should not):

Imposing limitations on freedom of expression brings along the consequences linked to excessive liberty as it results in **fewer channels for the disenfranchised and oppressed to voice their political opinions**.

Critical analysis

- Indeed, **freedom of speech is the cornerstone for the oppressed** to express their opinions.
 - Imposing censorship poses a problem since deviants who do not possess potent views are unable to express their political opinions without punishment.
- This causes a **political standstill**, and often **signs of an authoritarian and autocratic regime**.

Examples

- The **Arab Spring in 2011**, through new media, spread like wildfire across international borders within weeks, **instigating numerous countries to revolt against oppressive regimes**. Research from the **Project on Information Technology and Political Islam (PITPI)** found that **online revolutionary conversations often preceded mass protests on the ground**, and that **social media played a central role in shaping political debates** in the Arab Spring.
- In 2016, **Evan Mawarire** starting an online revolution through the **#thisflag** movement to embolden young Zimbabweans to stand up against **Robert Mugabe**, Zimbabwe's authoritarian President for 30 years. Consequently, **Mugabe's party had to step down**, and much of it can be attributed to the effective utilisation of new media by a courageous man.

Counter (Should):

However, unlimited freedom of expression granted could **destabilize the political system of the country**, which is undesirable. Consequentialist would point out how **negligence towards potential dangers of misguided political views may spark dire consequences** which **outweigh the initial benefits absolute freedom of expression has brought**. Hence, it is only logical to conclude that censorship is justified given the ethical and practical considerations.

TS3 (Should not):

Restrictions on the freedom of expression in the arts scene may **stifle crucial growth or breakthroughs in the arts and cultural sectors**, resulting in **negative cultural changes**.

Critical analysis

- In a rapidly modernizing world, it is precisely censorship in the arts that prevents societies to remain relevant. Thus, **in order to flourish culturally, we cannot afford to compromise any form of personal expression in arts**.
- While arts should ideally not be made to offend. **arts can aid in the development of society and pushing of boundaries by criticising aspects of society**.
- Censorship in the arts may **create a culture of fear**, which hinders the development of arts even further as local artists may leave the country in search for better prospects overseas, leaving the country **trapped in a cycle of cultural, artistic and developmental deficiency**.

Examples

- ***To Singapore, With Love*** is a film which **featured Singapore political exiles**. It was **banned** from public screenings **by the Media Development Authority, as it “undermines national security”**. Many film makers and civil society activists protested against the ban as the film **portrayed the flaws of Singapore in an organic, authentic manner**.

TS4 (Should):

Restrictions on freedom of speech should be warrant as it **allows the restriction of the circulation of sensitive or inappropriate materials** which could **disrupt social harmony and public morality**.

Critical analysis

- The diverse nature of our societies today justifies the need to prevent the spread of inappropriate and socially unacceptable content to protect the values **uphold morality** in our society.

Examples

- Banning of **extra-marital dating site Ashley Madison** in Singapore was a move by the Singapore government to abide by their moral guidelines and ensure that such vices do not perpetuate in society.

Counter (Should not):

Limiting the freedom of speech in an attempt to protect public morality may actually **compromise the lifestyles of minorities**, resulting in the **development of a close-minded, less vibrant and homogeneous society**. Minorities such as the homosexuals can feel oppressed since their way of life is criminalised and shunned by society.

Homosexuality in Singapore, especially in the art scene is strictly censored to prevent an outrage from the Christian and Muslim communities. A Singaporean media production company “Wild Rice” had \$20,000 dollars stripped from its funding because of the inclusion of a kiss scene between two men.

Rebuttal

A **consequentialist** will step in and argue from a **utilitarian point of view** that **minor sacrifices for the benefit of the majority in society is acceptable**. As long as the ultimate good for the society is achieved, it is justifiable for censorship to be imposed.

Conclusion

- Opponents from the consequentialism school of thought may argue that the **benefit gained by granting absolute freedom of expression must be weighed against the benefits of having some forms of censorship to maximise happiness for all affected individuals** following the theory of utilitarianism. Indeed, such comparisons are **ambiguous**, and a definite answer cannot be obtained. Therefore, it begs the question of whether it is worth the time and effort to fight for zero censorship and the absolute freedom of speech since **there is no definite merit** arising from either decision.
- **Unbridled freedom of expression** is too much of a good thing, which calls for law to step in to **strike an appropriate balance** between preserving public morality and freedom of expression.
- Given the examples discussed in this essay, I concede that **censorship is a necessary evil** which is beneficial to all from a pragmatic and ethical viewpoint.

2. Media and Society

Possible questions:

1. 'We can no longer trust the media.' Is this a fair comment?
2. The most divisive force in the modern world is new media. Do you agree?

Stand: **No trust**

Intro

- Media in its varied forms has **ostensibly infiltrated almost every aspect of our lives** and plays an undeniably **influential role in shaping the mindsets and perceptions of individuals**.
- Media indubitably involves a **selective relation, curation and representation of information to achieve certain purposes**, and this has given rise to the view that the media today is utterly devoid of truth. Nonetheless, while the media has shown itself to lacking credibility and objectivity, it would be **overly parochial** to declare that the media does not ever tell the truth.

TS1 (No trust):

The **sensationalism** of today's news due to the **pragmatic motives of media companies** has caused the media to **forgo its obligations to societies as channels to deliver unbiased and truthful reporting to the masses**.

To attain a larger piece of the profit pie, media companies **disregard business ethics** in twisting the truth and altering reality to affect the behaviours of consumers.

Critical analysis

- The use of exciting or shocking stories or language at the expense of accuracy, in order to provoke public interest or excitement.
- Such forthcoming examples highlight how biased and not entirely truthful content produced can reward the media companies with financial benefits.

Examples

- Media mogul **Rupert Murdoch** has built a media empire - he owns influential news companies such as Fox Corporation and News Corp, which in turn own influential newspapers such as The Daily Telegraph, The Sunday Times, and the Press Association, amongst others.
Whilst said news agencies are often relied upon to be purveyors of nothing but the truth, **they do not make enough profit**. Ultimately, a good portion of the wealth Murdoch has amassed from his media empire comes from **tabloids** - in other words **gossip articles and over-sensationalising issues (to draw readers' attention)** **is a money-making tool** in the media world.
- For instance, **The Sun** (a newspaper in the UK) published a newspaper with "**Queen Backs Brexit**" splashed over the front page in bold words. This **caused an upheaval** amongst the public as constitutionally; the Queen must remain politically neutral and not be involved in any political decisions. However, the actual article had nothing to do with the title, and the title served to only be 'clickbait', generating clicks.

TS2 (No trust):

The increasing utilisation of **biased reporting** and **carefully engineered content** aimed at swaying the **political opinions** of the populace to **fuel the political agendas** of governments has led to the loss of credibility in media today.

Critical analysis

- Indeed, **media reportage is not merely about the representation of bare facts**, but also the **necessary analysis and synthesis of information**, such as the motives behind policies and impacts due to a certain event.
- **The media as a medium is merely a conduit for the communication of inevitably interpreted information.**
- This gives the potential for media to be aligned with the predominant views and ideals of a specific political party in an attempt to influence voters in their choice, functioning as a **politically-tinted mouthpiece** of the particular party.
- However, such practices should not be encouraged, as **information related to politics should be presented in a fully transparent and truthful manner** as much as possible, in order to present voters with adequate information such that they are able to **make informed and rational decisions** about their livelihoods. The public who wholly take in the content would be **deluded** by such misrepresentation, and be misled to make voting decisions that could endanger their wellbeing and livelihoods.

Examples

- **Pro-Congress newspapers** in India such as **The Tribune** and **the Hindustan Times** consistently **bury the perils of the party among more hidden pages while positives are displayed prominently** on the front pages.
- In **China Global Television Network (CGTN)** coverage of the **2014 Ebola outbreak** in West Africa, 17% **emphasised China's benevolent role** in providing medical aid in an attempt to paint the Chinese Communist Party in a better light. This partiality towards China is unsurprising, considering how CGTN is indirectly owned by the Publicity Department of the Chinese Communist Party.

TS3 (No trust):

The media, in particular, the new media is untrustworthy when there exist **echo chambers** created by **algorithms** which causes **information received by each individual to be twisted to fit their taste**.

Critical analysis

- Individuals rely heavily on only a few selected channels of information due to the simple desire to engage in **confirmation bias**, where information that confirms their own beliefs and biases are favoured.
- Algorithms further exacerbates such issues on social media applications as well as news websites by creating a **feedback loop** where the more one enjoys a particular content, the more it would recommend it to him.
- One must explicitly realise that information disseminated by the media is not entirely trustworthy as they are **filtered, selected and personalized** to **support his prior knowledge and beliefs**. Therefore, they might not actually carry much value as such information **are not relevant and crucial to the world**. **Media's function to serve as a platform for open discussion as well as to inform and educate is lost.**

Examples

- Algorithms on Facebook have come under fire for **reinforcing political polarisation** by suggesting political news similar to what the reader has read before, instead of providing an objective, neutral political news feed.

TS4 (Trust):

However, there still exists **traditional forms of media** such as newspapers and magazines which **undergoes stringent vetting processes**, making them significantly **more reliable sources of factual information** that is worthy of trust.

Critical analysis

- Newspapers and magazines are **supported by an extensive and reliable network of sources**, as well as professional journalists and editors aiding in **fact-checking** news pieces before they are published.

- Experienced and trained journalists in traditional media help to curate and prioritise information. They provide what is crucial and relevant in the world today.
- In other words, traditional media has journalists act as fourth estate – they help to filter out certain points or views that may be false or damaging to society, uplifting the value of media in its ability to distribute reliable and safe information.
- This is in stark contrast with “citizen journalism” that is rampant online, where people report anything they want.
While it may seem like liberation from supposed censorship, controversial views, hate speech and unchecked facts ends up being disseminated, potentially threatening the social fabric.

Examples

- **Iran media:** All non-Iranian journalists seeking to report for foreign media from Iran must go through strict procedures. Journalists have to submit a formal request and submit a copy of their previously published work to the embassy. Only upon approval from authorities may the journalists obtain a visa to enter the country and report for their respective foreign news agencies

Rebuttal (No trust):

However, even taking this point to its strongest, it is nonetheless important to realise that **traditional media are on the decline** as companies continue to make the switch to digital platforms, where regulations and vetting processes are not as strict as before. With the rise of new media, it is only logical to conclude that the media in general is not trustable anymore.

Synthesis

- Ultimately, we can trust some forms of media over others. It is arguably inaccurate to interpret the media as a monolithic or homogeneous concept as it comprises of a myriad of organisations that involve various actors with differing agendas. Hence, adopting an absolute stance on this issue would show a simplistic and shallow analysis.
- In media, choice of what to report or omit within the limitations of space is also affected by human bias. Media is therefore imbued with an inherent subjectivity that lacks accuracy.
- Considering the inherent nature of the media which lacks objectivity, as well as the examples discussed in this essay, it is only logical to conclude that the media today is generally not trustable.

3. There is no such thing as bad publicity. Is this true?
4. Are all forms of attention good?

Stand: There is bad publicity (Publicity can be negative)

Intro

- With the omnipresence of media today, bad publicity may spread like wildfire, resulting in tarnished reputations.
- The statement posits that the merits of every form of press, even negative ones outweigh the perils they carry. However, this is patently untrue.

TS1 (There is no bad publicity):

Notoriety is beneficial when it manages to rally the public's emotions to galvanise cultural changes.

Critical analysis

- It is precisely the outrage generated by controversial article that compel netizens to act, providing a forceful impetus for changing deep-rooted and misguided traditions, and momentum for productive cultural changes to an otherwise obstinate and entrenched culture which has prevailed for decades.

Examples

- During the **infamous Nirbhaya rape case** which occurred in 2012, the Indian media's **sole focus on the victims** and their **refusal to identify and shame the perpetrators** aroused anger and unjust by the public. This placed **momentous pressure on Indian Government officials** and forced them to take immediate actions to protect Indian women from sexual violation, **improving the misogynistic culture in the country**.

Counter (There is bad publicity):

However, detractors are quick to point out how such incidents have tarnished the affected individuals' reputation and caused them to be viewed in a more negative light due to the publications of the scandal.

Rebuttal (There is no bad publicity):

That said, **even taking this argument to its strongest**, it is nonetheless more important to remember how such an image is only temporary, and the **resulting positive cultural changes can elevate the Indian society's image in the long run**.

TS2 (There is no bad publicity):

Bad publicity can serve as **novel marketing tactic** employed by businesses and public figures to **capture the attention of the audience** and **establish a certain reputation**, allowing them to gain monetary benefits.

Critical analysis

- With the pervasiveness of the media today, there is a **glut of digital advertising** by businesses and frequent posts by social influencers. It has thus become **increasingly difficult to convince the average Joe to pay for a certain product or service** online.
- As a result, many media companies and online public figures have resulted to **engineering controversial content online**, sparking heated debates or discussions online, generating attention in the form of clicks, views and discussions, which can translate into profit.

Examples

- Kim Kardashian's** rise to fame because of her leaked sex tape in 2007. Today, the Kardashian family is one of the most prominent and influential families in the world, with a successful reality show and even a billionaire in Kylie Jenner.
- During an official interview, the former **Abercrombie and Fitch** CEO blatantly pointed out how their clothing is not made for individuals who are "too fat and old".
- Similarly, representatives of **Victoria Secret** emphasised that the reason why they do not employ plus size models on their runway shows is because it is not attractive enough. Despite the initial outburst by netizens, it eventually led to the **formation of highly coveted brand names** because of the **exclusivity of their clothing**.

TS3 (There is bad publicity):

However, when **public figures and politicians** are implicated in publicity which revolves around injustice, they may be punished by a loss of trust from voters. Such consequences cause the most harm to revered public leaders who depend on their reputations and trustworthiness.

Critical analysis

- Such bad publicity can cause irreparable damage to the **public reputation** of political leaders, consequently causing their **policies and ideals to be ineffective** despite having a good motive.

Examples

- Singapore member of parliament (MP), **Tin Pei Ling** entered the political scene as a young woman and was deemed too inexperienced for the job, so much so that the revered politician Lee Kuan Yew stood up and exited the room the moment she spoke at the parliament house. Videos of the incident circulated on social media platforms such as Youtube, making her the **subject of mockery** in Singaporean politics. As a result, **her brave advocacy of single mothers and female politicians is quickly forgotten**. After this bout of infamy, Tin's **reputation as a trusted leader of Singapore has thus been smeared**.

Counter (There is no bad publicity):

However, it should be noted that **an increasingly educated society like Singapore's would be less likely to accept such one-sided portrayal** of Ms Tin **at face value**. Moreover, the Internet has made it a breeze to access substantial information, allowing one to judge more fairly.

Rebuttal (There is bad publicity):

That said, it is more important to consider how it would be **overly optimistic** to believe the majority of readers would spend time for research given the decreasing attention span of people. Furthermore, the **sensationalism of media today makes sourcing for truthful and informative articles an arduous task**. Consequently, this reduces the probability of the average reader having a more informed view on the matter.

Thus, in most instances, it would be more rational to expect the perils of such publicity to far outweigh its potential benefits.

TS4 (There is bad publicity):

Poor media exposure can also tarnish the **reputation of businesses** and cause significant economic loss.

Critical analysis

- Businesses involving the sales of its products or services is heavily dependent on the quality of it. Hence, they rely on a particularly good reputation to boost sales and stock prices.
- When such **reputation is tarnished** due to bad media exposure, they will suffer from significant economic loss.
- This well illustrates the impact bad publicity can inflict in terms of brand name and economic gains.

Examples

- Toyota suffered **a loss of faith in their brand name** because of manufacturing changes. Its decision to shift its manufacturing operations beyond Japan resulted in poor workmanship that forced the firm to have to recall over hundreds of thousands of units. **This destroyed the brand's historical reputation as the benchmark for reliability in the automobile industry**. Consequently, Toyota's stock prices plummeted.

Synthesis

- The concept of bad is a rather **subjective** and **nebulous** term.
- A cultural relativist may argue that publicity can be considered bad in one region and good in another. It would be **difficult to come up with a precise yardstick** for measuring whether publicity is good or bad as it depends largely on the culture and upbringing of the individual. It is therefore difficult to say with absolute certainty that bad publicity can always bring about a positive outcome.
- The criteria by which publicity is considered bad **should also be determined with reference to the impact it brings to others**. Celebrities like Kim Kardashian **may be effective in transferring initial notoriety into her eventual advantage**, but such cases also **encourage society to wage dignity for material goods**.

5. Information technology and social media has truly transformed the world.

(Impact of social media and IT)

Stand: Yes, it has transformed the world

Intro

- “What kills a skunk is the publicity it gives itself.” – 16th President of the United States, Abraham Lincoln
- As the quote **judiciously points out** the **value** and also the **potentially dire consequences of media**.
- Media, in particular social media which flourished in today’s world due to the advent of information technology has brought about incredible changes to our way of life.
- Although detractors may argue that the impact of social media and information tech is not universal as a significant part of the world still lacks access to such technology, ultimately, it is still hard to deny the massive changes that social media has brought about which has indeed transformed the world.

TS1 (Yes):

Information technology and social media has **served as a powerful tool** to **meet the communication demands of the fast-paced and globalised 21st Century**, far more effective than any other communication medium in history.

Critical analysis

- The advent of technology has allowed social media and other forms of media to disseminate information instantly from one corner of the world to another with no significant lag, allowing for **seamless interactions** between people.
- This has allowed for more than the maintaining of relationships, but also opened up more possibilities to increase work productivity, as video conference becomes a popular way to work.

Examples

- During the recent COVID-19 pandemic, billions around the world continued to work from home through video-calling services supported by information technology giants such as Tencent, Zoom and Google. Tencent’s Wechat Work has allowed over 30 million enterprises across China to resume work. More significantly, it has also allowed doctors to reach more remote regions of China and give out health advices as well as safety distancing instructions to combat COVID-19.

TS2 (Yes):

Social media manages to **rally the public’s emotions to galvanise positive cultural and societal changes**.

Critical analysis

- Social media has also allowed for a **platform for discussions** on **political or social issues** and allowed netizens to join power to create a powerful force for change.
- It is precisely the outrage generated by controversial article that compel netizens to act, providing a **forceful impetus** for **changing deep-rooted and misguided traditions**, and **momentum** for **productive cultural changes to an otherwise obstinate and entrenched culture** which has **prevailed for decades**.

Examples

- The, **Arab Spring in 2011** through new media, spread like wildfire across international borders within weeks, **instigating numerous countries to revolt against oppressive regimes**. Research from the **Project on Information Technology and Political Islam (PITPI)** found that **online revolutionary conversations often preceded mass protests on the ground**, and that **social media played a central role in shaping political debates** in the Arab Spring.

- In 2016, **Evan Mawarire** starting an online revolution through the **#thisflag** movement to embolden young Zimbabweans to stand up against **Robert Mugabe**, Zimbabwe's authoritarian President for 30 years. Consequently, Mugabe's party had to step down, and much of it can be attributed to the effective utilisation of new media by a courageous man.
- During the infamous **Nirbhaya rape case** which occurred in **2012**, the Indian media's **sole focus on the victims** and their **refusal to identify and shame the perpetrators** aroused anger and unjust by the public. This placed **momentous pressure** on Indian Government officials and forced them to take immediate actions to protect Indian women from sexual violation, providing a **forceful impetus** in **improving the misogynistic culture** in the country.

TS3 (Yes):

Social media **proliferates the expression and dissemination of foreign cultures**, introducing them to a larger audience who previously lacked the access to such content.

Critical analysis

- The **widespread and ubiquitous nature of social media** has allowed foreign cultures and influence to be available to audiences millions of miles away. One, who previously would have had to travel to the actual country to experience the culture can now do the same through the convenience of a phone or tablet.

Example

- Consider the rise of **K-pop**.
K-pop, otherwise known as Korean popular music, is a type of popular culture enjoyed worldwide. In 2018, K-pop experienced significant growth and became a 'power player', marking a 17.9% increase in revenue growth. It is estimated to be **worth 6.1 trillion won**.
Much of K-pop's success can be attributed to the rise of social media which opened up the doors to western markets and allowed Korean pop music and the sub-culture to be enjoyed by billions over the world.
GFRIEND's Me Gustas Tu music video has a total of 44 million views on YouTube, and approximately 70 % of those views came from the Europe and America regions, clearly elucidating how social media has aided in the increase in popularity of K-pop music and culture beyond Korean soil.

TS4 (No):

Detractors may argue that the rise of new media not truly transformed the world due to the fact that **a significant proportion of the world's population continue to lack access to the Internet and social media**.

Critical analysis

- One's access to the Internet actually involves much more beyond the device we hold in our hand. Many **crucial infrastructures** and **relevant industries** must be developed sufficiently before Internet can be implemented widely across a region/country.
For instance, satellites, receiving antennas as well as processor chips and battery technology must all be in place for a simple email to be sent over the phone.
- In parts of the developing world, where access to electricity and power is limited, and individuals are **more occupied with the more pressing bread and butter issues**, it is **impractical** and **unfeasible** to be involved in these technologies.
- Hence, it would be **erroneous** to assumed that every individual has access to such luxuries, and as a result it cannot be said with absolute certainty that IT and social media has truly transformed the world when its effects are only limited to and can be utilized by a small minority of the population who are able to closely follow up and update themselves with the latest advancements.

Example

- In a 2019 research study by Internet World Statistics, it revealed that **43% of the world's population does not have access to the Internet** and **in extension, social media**.
- In 2018, it was found that 61% of the population in Australia obtain their news through the Internet. On the other hand, in Senegal (in West Africa), only a mere 20% of the population get their news online.

Counter

However, it can be argued that **significant efforts are being made** to improve the situation and increase the availability of technology in poorer regions.

Projects such as "**One Laptop per Child**" launched in less developed countries aims to extend Internet accessibility to far-flung regions to counter such an issue. Amazon's recent "**Project Kuiper**" would put 3000 over satellites into orbit to **provide high-speed Internet to any point on the globe**.

Synthesis

- In conclusion, there is no denying that social media and IT are the **new kings of the era**, as it has drastically transformed our lives in the past few years in ways and magnitude never before in the past.
- However, one should note that "truly transformed" is a rather nebulous and subjective word. A cultural relativist may argue that it is difficult to come up with a precise yardstick for measuring whether one thing has truly transformed our lives as it depends largely on the culture and upbringing of the individual. It is therefore difficult to say with absolute certainty that bad publicity can always bring about a positive outcome.
- Ultimately, given the examples discussed in this essay, I concede that social media and information technology has indeed transformed our lives.

3. Advertisements

Possible questions:

1. Is it fair to expect advertisements to be truthful?
2. Consider the effectiveness of advertisements today.

Stand: **Yes, it is fair**

Intro

- **“Doing business without advertising is like winking at a girl in the dark”** – Marketing expert, Stuart H. Britt
- Advertisements are essentially **a public medium promoting a certain product or service or event**. To achieve its aim of doing so, some advertisements inevitably lose some of its credibility in an attempt to minimise the perils of its products and maximise the positives.
- “Truth in advertisements” may be an oxymoron.

TS1 (It is unfair):

Today’s **highly competitive business landscape** renders it extremely idealistic to uphold the expectation that businesses should be fully transparent with their advertisements, as they would be unable to compete with peers who **do not espouse business ethics**.

Critical analysis

- It must be taken into consideration that the **innate function of advertisements is to draw attention and subsequently highlight the features of the product** that are attractive to consumers.
- This may often involve exaggerating certain benefits of the product, or portraying it in an overly idealistic manner or even glorifying the product, hence, it is ultimately unfair to expect said advertisements to be completely truthful, as the main functions of advertising would then be unfulfilled, and a dichotomy regarding the purpose of advertisements would then arise.

Examples

- The **dangers of pre-workout meals** are **purposefully concealed** in advertisements to make its detriments less obvious. Before it was banned, **Jack3d** advertised itself as a ‘Super Performance’ pre-workout, while hiding the perils it carried. In December 2011, two soldiers died after using the pre-workout Jack3d, which contained the banned substance DMAA.
- Digital media company **Buzzfeed** constantly makes use of **native advertising**, in a bid to camouflage sponsored posts amongst their usual informative content.
One instance is American Express Canada teaming up with BuzzFeed in 2018 to promote their new credit card. BuzzFeed created a series of content aimed at highlighting dining spots and places to travel to **subtly advertise** for the credit card by encouraging viewers to travel and consume at those places using the cards. These content fit in well with BuzzFeed’s usual content, with the only minor difference being a tiny “sponsored” phrase placed at the top of the articles. Ultimately, this produced results that were 41% more efficient than the intended Key Performance Indicator, underscoring the effectiveness of native advertisement, and also how **biased and not entirely truthful content produced can reward the media companies with financial benefits**.

Rebuttal

Although **‘truth in advertising’ might be an oxymoron**, it is still crucial to note that **ethical advertising is becoming more prominent** in today’s landscape, as consumers are now **savvier** and **more alert in identifying blatant lies** present in advertisements, and the **idea of ‘being truthful’ has been put on a pedestal** more than ever now.

One sterling example is success of **DEATH cigarettes** which was manufactured in the UK, whose **completely honest and truthful stance on how smoking** does lead to death **unexpectedly made them more popular**.

TS2 (It is fair):

Advertisements should be fully honest, in order to **serve as a trigger in order to inspire an overall positive effect in the world**, especially where **serious environmental issues** are concerned.

Critical analysis

- Advertisements often seek to be visually pleasing and positive in a bid to draw consumers in, the reality is that when serious issues such as environmental issues or animal cruelty are concerned, advertisements should not seek to uphold a utopian image.
- Instead, advertisements should **leverage on the impact they can achieve**, and **use it to raise awareness** and spread messages.
In this case, advertisements should then be **wholly transparent**, and even be the **bearer of the ugly truth**, as it is only then will consumers then be aware of the issues that are going on, and the **gravity of such issues**, ultimately **galvanising a positive social change in society**.
- Whilst this may seem too blunt to some, it is only through using such mentally-stirring images and captions, that the ugly truth of animal cruelty can be effectively and memorably brought across to audiences.

Examples

- **World Wildlife Fund (WWF)** created a series of advertisements in 2019 as part of an awareness campaign targeted at addressing animal cruelty. The advertisements consisted of visually jarring images and captions, such as **a lion having a clown's face painted on it**, together with the striking sentence "Your amusement or my life". What must be noted is that the images used in the advertisements are all taken in real-life with minimum editing.

TS3 (It is fair):

In the same vein, advertising, such as **political advertising**, should be **presented in a fully unbiased and truthful manner**, so that **citizens are able to make S**.

Critical analysis

- Such practices should not be encouraged, as information related to politics should be presented in **a fully transparent and truthful manner** as much as possible, in order to present voters with adequate information such that they are able to **make informed and rational decisions about their livelihoods**.
The public who wholly take in the content would be **deluded** by such misrepresentation, and be misled to make voting decisions that could endanger their wellbeing and livelihoods.

Examples

- **Pro-Congress newspapers** in India such as **The Tribune** and **the Hindustan Times** consistently **bury the perils of the party among more hidden pages** while **positives are displayed prominently** on the front pages.
- In **China Global Television Network (CGTN)** coverage of the 2014 Ebola outbreak in West Africa, 17% emphasised China's benevolent role in providing medical aid in an attempt to paint the Chinese Communist Party in a better light. This partiality towards China is unsurprising, considering how CGTN is indirectly owned by the Publicity Department of the Chinese Communist Party.

TS4 (It is fair):

Finally, it is only fair to expect advertisements to be truthful, if they **influence vital aspects of human lives**, such as the health and wellbeing of individuals, to a large extent.

Critical analysis

- Even though advertisements seek to portray products in the most appealing way to consumers as possible in order to boost sales, and this may oftentimes involve a certain degree of deceptive advertising or adopting the lie of omission, instances in which the health and lives of consumers are neglected.
- The ultimate wellbeing and lives of consumers should not be taken as a chess piece in the eyes of corporations, amidst the ongoing game of seeking profit maximisation.

Examples

- For instance, one such weight loss product, '**BB Body**', claimed to help individuals lose weight within a few days, and that the product was made of ingredients that were natural, and would not result in any side effects. However, after consuming said product, one woman ultimately **lost consciousness** and risked losing her life due to severe heart failure. This was a result of the product including **undeclared substances that was banned by the Health Sciences Authority (HSA) in Singapore**, as such substances were known to be detrimental to human health.
- The dangers of pre-workout meals are **purposefully concealed** in advertisements to make its detriments less obvious. Before it was banned, **Jack3d** advertised itself as a 'Super Performance' pre-workout, while hiding the perils it carried. In December 2011, two soldiers died after using the pre-workout Jack3d, which contained the banned substance DMAA.

Synthesis

- Truth is a **subjective** and **nebulous** term.
- It is difficult to come up with a precise yardstick to measure the truthfulness of something.
- A cultural relativist will argue that one's perception of truth is very different from another as it largely depends on one's upbringing and culture.
- Given the examples discussed in this essay, it is justified to expect advertisements to be truthful.

4. New Media vs Traditional Media

Possible questions:

1. In the digital age, do newspapers and magazines still have a place in society?

Stand: **Still have a place**

Intro

- The rise of new media may make it seem as if the age of printed media has already past.
- Allow me to ask this question: do you remember the last time you picked up a physical copy of the news?

TS1 (Do not have a place):

The **advent of technology has ushered us into a new age of information**, resulting in the dwindling relevance of newspapers and magazines in modern society.

Critical analysis

- The fast pace of dissemination of information made possible by the progress of information technology has caused a **shift in the ever-changing media landscape**.
- The sheer convenience that social media brings about to our daily lives has resulted in it being the almost instinctive choice for the modern individual to obtain and consume news from.
The fact that **social media** platforms are **ubiquitous** and **easily accessible** (simply through our smartphones that are always with us), as compared to the relatively inaccessible forms of traditional media (**having to purchase a physical copy** of the news, or having to pay for subscription vs the free news that is available online), causes newspapers and magazines to **slowly, yet surely, to lose their place in modern society**.

Example

- The 2017 **Pew Research Center** survey of US consumers noted that **67% of Americans get their news from social media**. Similarly, another Pew Research Centre survey of 38 countries in the following year noted that a median of 42% surveyed expressed that they get their news from the Internet at least once a day.

TS2 (Still have a place):

Newspapers and magazines undergo **stringent vetting processes**, making them significantly **more reliable sources of factual information**, as compared to their digital counterparts.

Critical analysis

- Even though new media is a convenient and hassle-free channel to obtain news sources from, this characteristic may end up being a **double-edged sword**.
The copious amounts of news being published nearly every minute **causes news to (ironically) drown out news, as information is lost in the (literal) world wide web**.
- On the other hand, experienced and trained journalists in traditional media instead help to curate and prioritise information, providing what is crucial and relevant in the world today. Newspapers and magazines are **supported by an extensive and reliable network of sources**, and professional journalists aid in **fact-checking** news pieces before publishing them.
- In other words, traditional media has journalists act as a **fourth estate** - they help to filter out certain points of views or opinions that may be controversial or damaging to society, as compared to 'citizen journalism' that is rampant online, as people report anything they want. While this may seem like liberation from supposed censorship, controversial views or unchecked facts that end up being published may instead threaten social cohesion and public peace.

Example

- All non-Iranian journalists seeking to report for foreign media from Iran must go through strict procedures. Journalists have to submit a formal request and submit a copy of their previously published work to the embassy. Only upon approval from authorities may the journalists obtain a visa to enter the country and report for their respective foreign news agencies

TS3 (Still have a place):

Critics who argue that the rise of new media has rendered traditional media useless often overlook the fact that **a significant proportion of the world's population continue to lack access to the Internet and social media**, resulting in the **continued relevance** of such forms of print media.

Critical analysis

- One's access to the Internet actually involves much more beyond the device we hold in our hand. Many **crucial infrastructures** and **relevant industries** must be developed sufficiently before Internet can be implemented widely across a region/country. For instance, satellites, receiving antennas as well as processor chips and battery technology must all be in place for a simple email to be sent over the phone.
- In parts of the developing world, where access to electricity and power is limited, and individuals are **more occupied with the more pressing bread and butter issues**, it is impractical and unfeasible to be involved in these technologies.
- Hence, it cannot be assumed that every individual has access to such luxuries, and as a result the uprising of new media as sources of news **will never completely oust** the need and relevance for traditional forms of media as news sources.

Example

- In a 2019 research study by Internet World Statistics, it revealed that **43% of the world's population does not have access to the Internet and in extension, social media**.
- In 2018, it was found that 61% of the population in Australia obtain their news through the Internet. On the other hand, in Senegal (in West Africa), only a mere 20% of the population get their news online.

Counter

However, detractors may argue that **significant efforts are being made** to improve the situation and increase the availability of technology in poorer regions.

Projects such as "**One Laptop per Child**" launched in less developed countries aims to extend Internet accessibility to far-flung regions to counter such an issue. Amazon's recent "**Project Kuiper**" would put 3000 over satellites into orbit to provide high-speed Internet to any point on the globe.

Rebuttal

That said, these detractors are **too naïve** and **optimistic** as the reality is that **a notable proportion** of the world still **lacks the necessary infrastructure** to access new media.

TS4 (Have a place):

Newspapers and magazines serve as **valuable collectibles** that **continue to increase in value** even after fulfilling their initial purpose as providers of information and entertainment.

Critical analysis

- Newspaper and magazines have an **almost disposable nature** where they only serve to report on the news of the day and are outdated once the day has passed can be deemed to be wasteful and uneconomical. However, **it is this very nature which makes it valuable due to its limited quantity**.

- Newspapers and magazines also have historical value as they contain valuable information - such as reporting on historic events, or providing crucial information on certain issues - which may still serve to be extremely valuable for historians to study, even after centuries have passed.
- As compared to online news that may easily be deleted or lost amidst the (literal) world wide web, newspapers and magazines are definitely more substantial and reliable than their digital counterparts.

Example

- For instance, one of the most historical and valuable newspapers is a copy of 'The Pennsylvania Packet & Daily Advertiser', published in Philadelphia on September 18, 1787. This iconic newspaper was the first to announce the finalisation of the Constitution of the United States and has an auction record in excess of USD 200,000.
- eBay seller and paper collectibles expert, Matt Oran earns a living by selling vintage issues of magazines. Oran and his father first started selling periodicals after a friend sold them 30,000 copies of Life magazine at 50 cents each but were valued at 20 to 30 dollars.
- In 2007, a copy of Beeton's Christmas Annual 1887 magazine sold at a Sotheby's auction for \$156,000.

Synthesis

- The question draws a false dichotomy between digital media and print media in this digital age. This assumes that print media companies lack the means to go online to capture the younger audiences. However, this is a flawed assumption as many print media companies like The Straits Times in Singapore have indeed moved on the online platforms and social media.
- Hence, it is important not to mischaracterise these two types of media as mutually exclusive models, but recognise that in reality, most companies integrate both aspects to provide their viewers with the best experience.

2. Do social media truly promote diversity?

Stand: Social media promote diversity

Intro

- The advent of technology has ushered us into a new age of information. Social media being one of the greatest or arguably the worst invention of this century has definitely brought about many innovations in the way people interact.
- One would expect social media to excel at promotion of diversity due to its very nature of being a communication platform. Yet, the reality is that it is not so simple.

TS1 (Does not promote diversity):

Detractors may question social media's ability to promote diversity given that social media continues to be inaccessible to a significant proportion of the world's population.

Critical analysis

- One's access to the Internet actually involves more than just the device we hold in our hand. Many **crucial infrastructures** and **relevant industries** must be developed sufficiently before Internet can be implemented widely across a region/country. For instance, satellites, receiving antennas as well as processor chips and battery technology must all be in place for a simple email to be sent over the phone.
- It cannot be assumed that every individual has access to such luxuries, and as a result it cannot be said that social media truly promotes diversity, as even if it doesn't, it is limited to those who have access to the internet, neglecting those who do not.

Example

- In 2018, it was found that 61% of the population in Australia obtain their news through the Internet. On the other hand, in Senegal (in West Africa), only a mere 20% of the population get their news online.
- In a 2019 research study by Internet World Statistics, it revealed that **43% of the world's population does not have access to the Internet and in extension, social media.**

Rebuttal

That said, while I do concede that more has to be done to improve **broadband penetration** around the world, we must note how such projects have been **showing promising results** since there is a consistent growth of Internet usage in Third World countries.

TS2 (Does)

Social media promotes the diversity of cultural opinions by **providing open platforms to minorities, broadening the scope of information** that one has access to.

Critical analysis

- **Social media is a ubiquitous feature in the modern world, an interactive technology** which has allowed for the **rapid dissemination of shared information and personal opinions**.
Depending on the nature of information one receives, social media **could even alter or completely change one's long-held beliefs**.
- Social media has **equipped the marginalized with a say on issues that matter to them**, ensuring that they are not left behind.
- The introduction of social media has led to an **onslaught of new scientific evidence** as well as **personal stories** which **challenged the longstanding view that homosexuality was a sin**.
This aptly demonstrates the value of social media in **informing the populace** and **giving rise to dissenting views** in its ability to promote differences in opinions.

Examples

- A record high of **74% of American now believe same-sex marriage should be legal**, approximately **40% higher than it was thirty years ago**, according to the New York Times.
- In 2019, **Pink Dot SG**, a non-profit LGBT movement in Singapore **gathered a record 20,000 through support garnered from various social media platforms**.
- As of 2020, more and more countries are now pushing for LGBT rights and legalizing same-sex marriage, evident from the United States in a historic Supreme Court ruling in July 2015.

TS3 (Does not)

Social media does not promote diversity when there exist **echo chambers** created by **algorithms** which causes information received by each individual to be **twisted to fit their taste**.

Critical analysis

- Individuals rely heavily on only a few selected channels of information due to the simple **desire to engage in confirmation bias**, where information that confirms their own beliefs and biases are favoured.
- Algorithms further exacerbates such issues on social media applications as well as news websites by creating a **feedback loop** where the more one enjoys a particular content, the more it would recommend it to him.
- One must explicitly realise that information disseminated by the media is not entirely diverse as they are **filtered, selected and personalized to support his prior knowledge and beliefs**.
Media's function to serve as a platform for open discussion as well as to inform and educate is lost.

Examples

- Algorithms on Facebook have come under fire for **reinforcing political polarisation** by suggesting political news similar to what the reader has read before, instead of providing an objective, neutral political news feed.

TS4 (Does)

Social media **proliferates the expression and dissemination of foreign cultures**, introducing them to a larger audience who previously lacked the access to such content.

Critical analysis

- The **widespread and ubiquitous nature of social media** has allowed foreign cultures and influence to be available to audiences millions of miles away. One, who previously would have had to travel to the actual country to experience the culture can now do the same through the convenience of a phone or tablet.

Example

- Consider the rise of **K-pop**.
K-pop, otherwise known as Korean popular music, is a type of popular culture enjoyed worldwide. In 2018, K-pop experienced significant growth and became a 'power player', marking a 17.9% increase in revenue growth. It is estimated to be **worth 6.1 trillion won**.
Much of K-pop's success can be attributed to the rise of social media which opened up the doors to western markets and allowed Korean pop music and the sub-culture to be enjoyed by billions over the world.
GFRIEND's Me Gustas Tu music video has a total of 44 million views on YouTube, and approximately 70 % of those views came from the Europe and America regions, clearly elucidating how social media has aided in the increase in popularity of K-pop beyond Korean soil.

Synthesis

- Ultimately, social media do **serve as productive platforms** for people to not just merely express their different views, but also be on the receiving end of those views.

5. Morality of Media

Possible questions:

1. 'The news today deals with what is popular, rather than what is important.' How far do you agree with this statement?

Stand: Disagree

Intro

- **"Truth and news are not the same thing." – American publisher, Katharine Graham**
- Just as the quote precisely points out, **news today no longer holds credit in publishing the truth.**
- Indeed, as news today shift towards attention grabbing articles on trivial matters in an attempt to sell, they no longer serve its function to inform and educate the masses on pressing issues that faces the society.
- However, it must be noted that the increasing trend of activism together with the rise of social media has forced a shift in directive. Some news outlets also choose to preserve strong adherence to their role as the **fourth estate**, aligning their reports with media ethos.
- One should also note the false dichotomy drawn in the question between popular and important, as some pressing issues that the society faces are also popular.

TS1 (Agree):

The **sensationalism** of today's news due to the **pragmatic motives of media companies** has caused the media to **forgo its obligations to societies** as **channels to deliver unbiased and truthful reporting to the masses**, disseminating what is popular rather than important in order to **attain a larger piece of the profit pie.**

Critical analysis

- Such forthcoming examples highlight how most media companies have succumbed to capitalise on trivial issues which grabs attention in a bid to remain profitable.

Examples

- For instance, media mogul **Rupert Murdoch** has built a media empire - he owns influential news companies such as Fox Corporation and News Corp, which in turn own influential newspapers such as The Daily Telegraph, The Sunday Times, and the Press Association, amongst others.
Whilst said news agencies are often relied upon to be purveyors of nothing but the truth, they do not make enough profit. Ultimately, a good portion of the wealth Murdoch has amassed from his media empire comes from **tabloids** - in other words **gossip articles** and **over-sensationalising issues (to draw readers' attention)** **is a money-making tool** in the media world.

TS2 (Disagree):

Newspapers and magazines undergo **stringent vetting processes**, making them significantly **reliable sources of factual information**, which focuses on delivery unbiased, important information to the masses.

Critical analysis

- Experienced and trained journalists in traditional media instead help to curate and prioritise information, providing what is crucial and relevant in the world today. Newspapers and magazines are **supported by an extensive and reliable network of sources**, and professional journalists aid in **fact-checking** news pieces before publishing them.
- In other words, media, in particular traditional media has journalists act as a **fourth estate** - they help to **filter out certain points of views or opinions that may be controversial or damaging to society**, delivering

what is important to the population as compared to sensationalism that is rampant in new media today, which focus solely on profiting.

Example

- The **BBC, USA Today, AXIOS** are all examples of news companies where news undergoes stringent vetting processes before it is published to ensure political neutrality, as well information accuracy and reliability. According to the **AllSides Media Bias Chart**, the three media companies rank top in their credibility and neutrality ranking.
- All non-Iranian journalists seeking to report for foreign media from Iran must go through strict procedures. Journalists have to submit a formal request and submit a copy of their previously published work to the embassy. Only upon approval from authorities may the journalists obtain a visa to enter the country and report for their respective foreign news agencies

TS3 (Disagree):

Furthermore, the increasing trend of activism, amplified by the rise of social media, has forced a shift in directive where what is popular is also what is important as media companies are forced focus on the important and popular social issues.

Critical analysis

- Such example clearly elucidates the importance for media to align their stance and content to that of the public to avoid boycotting from the public.

Example

- The **#StopHateforProfit** campaign which was organised by civil rights activists has had thousands of companies, celebrities as well as netizens boycott Instagram and Facebook by freezing their accounts and withdrawing advertisements in protest the platform's handling of hate speech and misinformation. This was a response to **Facebook's refusal to remove a hate comment, posted by President Trump** during the Black Lives Matter protests. This was in contrast to Twitter, which labelled it as glorifying violence and removed the comment immediately.
- During the infamous Nirbhaya rape case which occurred in 2012, the public's anger and uproar at the horrific incident as well as demanding harsh punishment on the perpetrators placed momentous pressure on the Indian media and follow-up reports and articles lasted several months even after the incident.

Synthesis

- Ultimately, popular issues and important issues are not always mutually exclusive concepts that exist in separate vacuums. Often, it is possible for global events to be popular and important concurrently, which makes the distinction between both concepts ill-defined.
- Given the examples discussed in this essay, I am in disagreement with the statement, as the news today do focus on the pressing global issues as well.

2. Consider the claim that purpose of the media is not simply to convey the truth, but to make it interesting.

Stand: Agree

Intro

- **“Truth and news are not the same thing.”** – American publisher, Katharine Graham
- Just as the quote precisely points out, media today no longer holds credit in publishing the truth.
- Indeed, as news today shift towards attention grabbing articles on trivial matters in an attempt to sell, they no longer serve its function to inform and educate the masses on pressing issues that faces the society.
- Some may argue that media should not seek to downplay truths in a bid to make it interesting for audiences, as this may end up diluting its key purpose - which is to disseminate truthful and unbiased information to the masses.
- However, one must realize that **without engaging reader first, there would be no one to disseminate truth to.** In a more practical sense, media companies must also make its content interesting to sustain profits. By making truths more interesting, media can also guide its audience to think more critically and analytically. Hence, I disagree with the statement.

TS1 (Disagree):

The media **should not seek to downplay truths in a bid to make it interesting for audiences,** as this may end up diluting its key purpose - which is to **disseminate truthful and unbiased information to the masses.**

Critical analysis

- Though there are some instances in which **wholly unbiased truths** that are presented to the public are **hard pills to swallow**, or **unbelievable horrors**, it must be considered that journalistic transparency is vital in informing and educating the public.
- Especially so in serious issues such as war, **perhaps it is only through mentally-stirring pieces of information or even images of jarring nature that the public will fully understand the gravity of the situation,** sans(without) the regulation, censorship and obfuscation of truth by authoritative bodies, in a bid to keep their citizens oblivious in a bubble of passiveness.

Examples

- For instance, one of the most iconic photos taken during the Vietnam war was **‘The Terror of War’** by **Nick Ut in 1972.** Informally known as the **‘Napalm Girl’**, the **Pulitzer-prize winning photograph** depicted a group of children running away from a burning village, with focus being drawn to a naked girl crying, as her back was completely burnt by the fire.
When the photo was first published, there was **major public outcry regarding the presentation of the raw impact of conflict and child nudity.** However, **without it depicting the horrors of the war with such transparency to the public, the truths of the cruelty of war would also not be revealed.**

TS2 (Agree):

Without first piquing the interest of the readers, there would be few recipients of any truth conveyed by the media in the first place.

Critical analysis

- Whilst it may seem almost unethical to package and sugar coat truths before presenting them to the public (the idea of ‘clickbait’), the nature of the populous today makes it unavoidable.
- Thanks to the uprising of social media and technology, people are used to and reliant on the idea of instant gratification - they want things quickly and instantaneously. As a result, the attention span of the modern individual is extremely short.

- Without presenting seemingly 'drab' truths and news articles with eye-catching titles or descriptions, it is highly unlikely that they would attract any form of readership at all. In the end, such truths and information would not be relayed to the public, and the media would fail to meet its' purpose of informing and educating the public.

Examples

- For instance, **The Sun** (a newspaper in the UK) published a newspaper with "**Queen Backs Brexit**" splashed over the front page in bold words. This caused an upheaval amongst the public as constitutionally; the Queen must remain politically neutral and not be involved in any political decisions. However, the actual article had nothing to do with the title, and the title served to only be 'clickbait'. Nonetheless, it generated readership and encouraged the public to read up and educate themselves about Brexit, which was an important political issue at that time.

TS3 (Agree):

The **dwindling relevance of traditional media** makes it **prioritise profit-earning** - in a bid to stay afloat, media may end up turning to sensationalism to sustain viewership.

Critical analysis

- Although the intended function of media is to educate and inform the public with as much transparency as possible, there are practical constraints to this.
- News agencies are also businesses that prioritise profit-maximisation. With the advent of technology and the increasing presence of online news outlets, traditional news agencies must seek ways to sustain viewership and continue to earn profits in order to stay afloat. This may include sensationalising titles of news articles, or even directing more resources to produce 'lifestyle' content (i.e. gossip, tabloids). As sensationalism sells, this would ensure that there is a steady source of income to keep the business running.

Examples

- For instance, media mogul **Rupert Murdoch** has built a media empire - he owns influential news companies such as Fox Corporation and News Corp, which in turn own influential newspapers such as The Daily Telegraph, The Sunday Times, and the Press Association, amongst others. Whilst said news agencies are often relied upon to be purveyors of nothing but the truth, they do not make enough profit. Ultimately, a good portion of the wealth Murdoch has amassed from his media empire comes from tabloids - in other words gossip articles and over-sensationalising issues (to draw readers' attention) is a money-making tool in the media world.

TS4 (Agree):

The media should also seek to make the truth more interesting to **inspire their viewership to be informed** and **analytical individuals**.

Critical analysis

- Whilst the media should indeed uphold its **intended function of informing the public through presenting truths in a fully transparent manner**, it must also bear in mind that it should fulfil one of its other functions - **interpretation**.
- The media should not be fixated with solely presenting the bland truth to the public, but also put forth views, opinions and judgements - this will encourage **the public to form their own views and hold their own discussion**, as there is **more than one angle to an issue**.
- By offering interesting and potentially controversial opinions on an issue, this will help generate buzz around issues; ultimately this will **not only help develop a merely informed public, but a public that is also opinionated**.
- Such examples clearly demonstrate how media can also educate while making its content interesting.

Examples

- News satire television program **Last Week Tonight with John Oliver** not only presents factual news to its audience, but also **offers differing, and often controversial, commentary** on the news of the week (hence the satire nature). Ultimately, the show serves to **not only disseminate factual news** to its audience, but also **probe them into viewing the issue from various angles, rather than take the information two dimensionally**.
- Mobile application and websites such as **Reddit** and **Zhihu** allow its users to discuss with one another in **a forum like setting**. Users can interact with one another by upvoting, downvoting or giving a direct reply.

Conclusion

- In conclusion, I agree that the media has to make truth interesting, although I also recognise some cases where the cold, hard truth should be delivered raw to the audience in order to achieve its purpose.
- Ultimately, entertainment values have to be used in such a way that **strikes an appropriate balance** between presenting the facts in an interesting way but not too much that it dilutes the truth. Whilst it is justified to make truth entertaining, it should not be abused.
- Given the examples discussed in this essay, it is definitely justified that media should make truth entertaining.